BECCATOOTILEDIT

Travel Radio Australia and we are here at the International Golf Travel Market and I've run into Becca Tootle who's from Tourism Northern Ireland and Becca welcome to the program. Hi Jeff, pleasure to be with you. Northern Ireland has become such an iconic destination for people.

It's such a beautiful region of Ireland, so welcoming and you have some of the best tourist attractions in the entire world including in Belfast. There's the Titanic Exhibition and that's what I suppose Belfast is most well known for but there's a ton of other things to do in Northern Ireland. Tell us about a few of them.

Absolutely, we have our experience brand which is Embrace the Giant Spirit and there is a multitude of experiences on offer. We're really proud now that we're here promoting golf but the golf offering matches the experience offering, it truly is world-class. We've got the Giant's Causeway, Carricka Reed Rope Bridge which is on coast near Port Rush Golf Club, so we find a lot of people kind of sloop off there for the afternoon and they can do national heritage trust things, there's an abundance of things they can do, private guided tours.

We're also seeing a lot of distilleries pop up and that's really exciting. We have the Titanic Distillery, I know you mentioned the Titanic Museum, there's a distillery down there now too, there's the hotel which people pop into, they can see where the drawing plans were formed, they can really learn about how it happened and you know really delve into the history there which is great. When I say distilleries and stuff, you think of just going there and seeing where things are brewed and chatting through and it's not just that, it's actually you know them coming out and doing private tours and there's a lot of walking food tours.

The city centre itself is bustling and the food and drink offering there is excellent. We've had Niall McKenna, a famous chef, he's opened Waterman House Restaurant and he has a cookery school so yeah there's an abundance of activities off the course that people can enjoy. Well it's a tremendous area to just fly into Belfast as a magnificent airport as a hub and once you're there, half an hour away out of Belfast, the greatest not only golf courses but some of the most greatest castles and tell us about a few of those that are just a short trip out of Belfast.

Yeah absolutely, I mean when you speak of the airport that's definitely worth noting, they saw a massive investment a couple of years ago and feedback especially from our operators was really taken on board, it's been streamlined, it's got new restaurants, the security process is top-notch now so that's excellent. We also have Derry Airport which is seeing some more flights coming through and that's really exciting and definitely, I mean just outside of Port Rush Golf Club, one of our most famous that obviously hosted the open, you have Dunlice Castle so a lot of people will stop off there, absolutely seeped in history. Near Castle Rock we have Washington Temple and yeah people will go there, spend some time and they can see the course, they can see the sea from there and one minute they can be soaking up history and the next minute they're hitting golf

balls, the next minute they're enjoying the 19th total so there truly is something for everyone.

A bit about your background, you've just come back from having a lovely wee baby and congratulations and how did you get into being connected with Tourism Northern Ireland? Yeah actually, funny enough chatting to you, I lived in Sydney for a few years, decided 2019, I decided to give home a go and see how I got on, I said I would be there for six months and if I didn't settle I would go back to Australia. Eight years later, still here, so I started in 2019 which was six months before the 140th open, it was first time we had the tournament in 78 years and don't quote me on that, could be 79 but somewhere in there, first time we'd had it in a very long time, it was monumental for us truly and it was the most successful open outside of St Andrews so it was such an accolade for us and I started the role six months before that, temporary contract, delved right into the world of golf and very pleased to say that after the success of the open a couple of months later I was kept on permanently and we're now seven years on, I have another open under my belt, worth talking about I suppose, worldwide screen so I know everyone's aware but we saw the open return within six years which again massive accolade, it's pretty unheard of and you know we punch above our weight I think sometimes people don't expect us to have the events that we do and them to be such a success but truly it was all over again and I think this time around it was very exciting for me because I got to be there from start to finish, as I said I only came in before the 2019 one, six months before so it was all systems go but you didn't get to see everything and prior to the actual event and the organisation of it this time around I did and absolutely loved that and look we didn't get a win from Rory McElroy which was devastating but he went on to have an incredibly successful year then and got a screen jacket and off the back of that we've seen even more interest in golf and he really does help to put us on the map, since then I fell absolutely in love with the industry with what I get to see of Northern Ireland and I have a true passion for shellin' it to people because you know when people come they they don't have necessarily the expectations that your idea that have already been we know how good it is so they're blown away every time and that gives me great reward it's it's our country and I love that other people love it so much yes and tell us a couple of offbeat things that you would recommend say someone comes in as a tourist a real local thing to do maybe it might be a restaurant or an experience that would recommend that a tourist might not really know about but you know is really a must-see yeah I mean I'll just tell you one of my favorites so there is a little pub called Kelly Sellers which is right in the city centre and you go in there you get a bowl of Irish tea you get homemade wheat and some Irish butter there's fiddly-dee music on it's always busy you'll always get chatting to a local yeah it's just a perfect way for golfers to finish off a day on the course you've also got Cathedral Quarter which is our now very much so bustling hub and lots of bars there there and you have a beautiful display which has lots of umbrellas I don't know if you're familiar with it and it has all the days of the week and people like to go there and have a photo and then they can stop into the Duke of York and see some excellent memorabilia and have a little Guinness in there we've got the friend-of-hand whiskey bar just round the corner they do now I have a background they've expanded and you can do private whiskey tasting but you can also just go in and have a little look or buy a little something while you're there I know you

were interested to begin in Belfast and city centre itself lots of little quaint things to do there and as I say there's always someone that has a story we're always happy to have visitors and we always love to tell you why we love it so much so yeah you'll find me with a little bowl of tea on a pint of Guinness and Kelly Sellers yes it's so friendly in Northern Ireland that people are also love to meet people from far away like Australia it's like it's like being a little superstar when you run over there because people think oh we don't we've all the other thing they say is we've got family and you must get that too do you know so-and-so or so-and-so definitely and even that itself there's experiences now you know London itself to that there's things you can do where people come and they go and learn about their heritage and you know Australian American closer to home Liverpool and stuff that that has so many Irish immigrants that traveled and went looking for a better life because obviously you know Northern Ireland didn't always look how it does now and such an excellent place to live now but yeah you know that's something that activities are leaning into and I love that you know people can come from the other side of the world but they can say to me do you know Willie John Sheehan absolutely and surely half the time there probably is some far far removed connection that we do but yeah that's definitely one I don't have a ton of information on it but that's one to look into as well for that off the time course you know something real authentic where you can go out with someone and they can tell you even the black taxi tours when you do them you'll feel like you've known those guys your whole life and they will take you off stop you at the peace wall you can get out and sign it and I imagine every Aussie that comes thinks that taxi man is family by the end of it so yeah lovely to have our visitors and especially lovely to chat to you and Aussie and hear the accent again with you today. Thank you so much Becca.

Becca Tootle from Tours of Northern Ireland how can people find out more online Becca? Yeah absolutely they can visit our website which is Discover Northern Ireland there they'll find a dedicated golf page but just given we've discussed you know the broader attractions the castles the resorts are excellent hotel offering they can go there and have a look at everything and what would be good for them to do also is we have some sample itineraries we're objectively small it's easy to get around so they could have a look and you know see what's close to where and what might look like a good sample itinerary for them my email address will be on there as well but it is golf at tourismai.com so if there's any general inquiries love to hear from you and please send them to there thanks a million. Becca and give that lovely little new baby a big cuddle from all of us in Australia. Thanks so much Jeff.